

To Our Supporters:

We are proud to share the progress and impact of Cayuga's Watchers during the 2025-26 academic year.

This year marked a major shift in how bystander intervention training is delivered on campus. In a newly revived partnership with Cornell's Sorority & Fraternity Life (SFL), Cayuga's Watchers became the primary required external training program for sorority and fraternity life. We helped Cornell move away from a standardized video-based alcohol education module and instead adopted a peer-led, in-person model delivered by our student-trainers. As a result, **Cayuga's Watchers is now the only required outside training program for fraternities and sororities.**

This change reflects something we have believed for a long time – that effective training cannot be passive. Students learn best from each other, in real conversations, grounded in situations they actually face. Our model meets students where they are and gives them practical tools they can use immediately.

At its core, Cayuga's Watchers remains focused on a simple goal: Helping students recognize risky situations and step in when it matters. While we originally operated by placing trained "Watchers" at events, we made a deliberate shift to a training-first model in recent years. That decision has allowed us to scale our impact and reach more students across campus.

Expanding Our Reach and Institutional Role

This year, Cayuga's Watchers returned to campus at scale. Through our partnership with SFL, we trained a large portion of sorority and fraternity life, with a requirement that all new member classes complete our program. Our goal was to reach every chapter on campus, and as of May 2026, **we have reached every new member class in the MGFC, IFC, and Panhellenic councils at Cornell**, with a few chapters opting to mandate training for all members.

In just the Spring semester, more than 886 students completed training sessions. Post-training surveys show strong outcomes:





These results reinforce what we consistently see – when students engage in peer-led, discussion-based training, they leave feeling more confident and more prepared to act.

In addition to formal training, we expanded our presence on campus this spring through tabling and direct outreach. These efforts helped introduce Cayuga's Watchers to a broader audience and created opportunities to engage students in conversations around party safety and bystander responsibility. While still early, this work is an important step toward expanding beyond sorority and fraternity life.

What Makes Cayuga's Watchers Different

As our role on campus has grown, a natural question has come up: how is Cayuga's Watchers different from other required training programs?

The difference starts with who delivers the training. Our sessions are led by students. This peer-to-peer approach builds trust and creates a more open environment where participants are willing to engage honestly.

We also focus on action. Many programs are designed around awareness or compliance. Our training is built around intervention – what to look for, how to step in, and how to do it in a way that feels realistic in a social setting. We spend time on practical strategies like distraction, group intervention, and reading situations before they escalate.

The format matters too. Our sessions are interactive and scenario-based. Students are not just listening – they are participating, reacting, and thinking through situations they are likely to encounter. That leads to better retention and more confidence.

We have also heard directly from student leaders that this approach fills a gap. There is a strong preference for peer-led training over generic online modules, and many students see Cayuga's Watchers as more relevant to their actual experiences.

Many wonder what "intervention" actually looks like in practice. A key part of our training is helping students understand that intervention does not need to be confrontational or aggressive to be effective. For example, we walk students through scenarios where someone at a party may be acting in a predatory or concerning way toward another student. Rather than escalating the situation or creating conflict, participants learn practical techniques like distraction, checking in with the individual, involving friends, redirecting attention, or using group intervention to safely remove someone from an uncomfortable situation. These examples help students see that intervention is not just about acting alone – it is often most effective when friends work together to protect one another and create safer social environments.

Investing in Student Leadership

Cayuga's Watchers is powered by student trainers. This year, we recruited and supported a strong group of five facilitators who led sessions across campus.

We compensate trainers \$75 per session, with two trainers leading each training. As the number of sessions has increased, supporting these students has become our primary expense. This model allows us to recruit committed, capable leaders and maintain a high standard for every session.

We were also fortunate to have strong leadership from our Graduate Student Advisor, Gabby Scott, who played a key role in coordinating trainings, supporting student trainers, and helping scale the program across campus.

Financial Overview

Cayuga's Watchers continues to operate with a focus on sustainability and impact. Our primary expenses include insurance, student trainer compensation, program development, and outreach efforts. As training volume increased this year, so did our investment in supporting trainers and maintaining program quality.

In 2025-26, our supporters contributed more than \$11,000 to advance the mission of Cayuga's Watchers. Over the past two years, total giving has exceeded \$28,000 – reflecting generous first and multi-year donations. **Every gift, at every level makes a difference and we generously thank our donors for their commitment to our mission.**

Looking Ahead

This year created strong momentum, and we are focused on building on it. Our first priority is to continue coverage across the sorority and fraternity system and move toward full participation across all member classes. Beyond that, we are planning to expand into other areas of campus life where this training can have real impact. In the coming year, we plan to:

- Expand training to varsity and club sports teams
- Partner with student organizations / Cornell Student Assembly
- Integrate Cayuga's Watchers into fall new member education for SFL
- Continue campus engagement efforts to build awareness

Our long-term goal is to make bystander intervention a core part of the student experience at Cornell. This year showed what is possible when the right model meets the right moment. Cayuga's Watchers is proud to be playing a central role in how Cornell approaches student safety.

Thank you for your continued support.

Sincerely,



Drew Lord
Chairman, Board of Directors